

Understanding

Alzheimer's Disease

A guide for patients and families

What is Alzheimer's Disease?

A Brain Condition

Alzheimer's disease is the most common cause of dementia.

It gradually affects memory, thinking, language, and the ability to carry out everyday tasks.

It is not a normal part of ageing.

Progressive Nature

Alzheimer's is progressive, it worsens over time.

Symptoms usually develop slowly over years, not days or weeks.

Each person's experience is different, the pace and pattern of change varies.

Early Signs to Look For

These signs do not always mean Alzheimer's, but they are worth discussing with a doctor.



Memory Loss

Forgetting recently learned information, important dates, or asking the same questions repeatedly



Confusion

Losing track of dates, seasons, or the passage of time; getting lost in familiar places



Language

Struggling to find words, follow conversations, or stopping mid-sentence without knowing how to continue



Behaviour

Changes in mood, personality, or withdrawal from social activities and hobbies

What Happens in the Brain

01

Amyloid Plaques

Abnormal protein fragments called amyloid build up between nerve cells, disrupting communication between neurons.

02

Tau Tangles

Inside neurons, a protein called tau collapses into twisted tangles, blocking the transport of nutrients and signals.

03

Neuron Loss

Over time, affected neurons stop functioning and die. The brain shrinks, and connections between areas are lost.

These changes begin years, sometimes decades, before symptoms appear.

How Is It Diagnosed?

There is no single test. Diagnosis involves a combination of assessments.

1

Clinical Assessment

A doctor will review your medical history, ask about symptoms, and speak with someone who knows you well. Memory and thinking tests help assess cognitive function.

2

Blood Tests

Used to rule out other possible causes of memory problems such as thyroid issues, vitamin deficiencies, or infections.

3

Brain Imaging

MRI or CT scans allow doctors to see brain structure and rule out other conditions. PET scans can sometimes detect amyloid plaques directly.

4

Specialist Referral

A neurologist, geriatrician, or memory clinic specialist may be involved for a more detailed assessment and confirmed diagnosis.

Living with Alzheimer's

Daily Challenges

- Managing daily tasks like cooking or finances
- Remembering names, appointments, and recent events
- Navigating familiar places
- Communicating thoughts clearly
- Changes in sleep, mood, and behaviour
- Maintaining independence over time

Support Strategies

- Maintain a consistent daily routine
- Use reminders, notes, and calendars
- Stay socially and mentally active
- Gentle physical activity where possible
- Create a safe, familiar home environment
- Accept help — it takes strength, not weakness

Support & Care



For Caregivers

Caring for someone with Alzheimer's is meaningful but demanding. Seek relief care, join support groups, and remember that looking after yourself enables you to care for others.



Treatment Options

There is currently no cure, but medications can help manage symptoms. Cholinesterase inhibitors and memantine may slow decline. Non-drug approaches such as routine, activity, and communication are equally important.



Emotional Support

Feelings of grief, anxiety, or frustration are entirely normal, for both the person with Alzheimer's and those around them. Psychological support and counselling can help.



Key Takeaway

An Alzheimer's diagnosis is not the end of the story.

With the right support, information, and care,
people with Alzheimer's and their families can
continue to live with meaning, connection, and dignity.

You are not alone.